STABILITY / UPTIME

ELEVATED

THIRD-PARTY OUTAGE DEPENDENCY

Your payment provider is down with no recovery ETA. Your product has no fallback pathway — every transaction attempt is failing. Revenue has stopped. Customers are asking why they cannot complete purchases.

Third-party dependencies are reliability liabilities that do not appear in your own SLOs but directly affect your users. The resilience pattern is to design for degradation: queue payment requests and retry when the provider recovers, offer alternative providers as fallback, surface clear and honest status messages to users rather than generic error pages, and set up dependency health monitoring so your alerting fires the moment a provider degrades — ideally before your users notice. Service dependency mapping (knowing every external call your system makes and what the failure mode is for each) is a foundational SRE practice. The Netflix Simian Army philosophy applies here: if a dependency can fail, assume it will, and build accordingly.

You inherit your dependencies' reliability. Their outage is your problem unless you designed for it.

TEAM DISCUSSION

Do you have fallback providers, graceful degradation, and clear customer messaging ready for third-party failures?